



Out of this WORLD

AS FAR AS WE KNOW, Earth is the only planet that sustains life. However, if you think about how many stars and planets there are in the Universe, chances are that there are other living things out there. But would they be the same as the plants, animals, fungi, and bacteria we see around us?
Maybe one day we'll find out.

IS THERE OTHER LIFE IN OUR SOLAR SYSTEM?

We have yet to detect life on the other planets and moons in our solar system. Only Earth lies in the habitable zone, but from what has recently been discovered about extremophiles (see p.88–89), scientists suspect that there could be traces of life on Mars or the moons Enceladus, Europa, Io, and Titan. We know that some bacteria can thrive in the hostile conditions found on these worlds.

ALIEN VISITORS?

For aliens to land on Earth they would have to overcome the problems of space travel. It took 3.5 billion years for life on Earth to become capable of visiting our own Moon, so any aliens would need to come from a planet where life has been around for a long time. Few planets are old or stable enough for that to have happened.

NO PLACE LIKE HOME

Out of the eight planets in our solar system, life only exists on Earth. This is because Earth lies in what is called the habitable zone. This is the distance a planet has to be from its star for water to be liquid and is the reason why there is no life on our neighbours, Venus and Mars. The planet also needs to have a hot interior and enough gravity to hold on to an atmosphere.

